My stay in Chakrata and tenure as the AQ was a great learning experience that was to stand me in good stead in later years. As the AQ, I was also the ex-officio member of the Cantonment Board, another grey area not known to many. In fact, as I was to learn later, in most foreign armies, the toppers from various courses such as the DSSC were sent to logistics billets, these being the more challenging ones. Needless to say, all these multifarious tasks kept me busy from dawn to dusk, even busier than what I had been as the BM. It was not just a desk-bound job. Along with the Commandant, we also used to visit the Vikas Battalions that were allotted to various formations of the Army. On such visits, apart from the Commandant, his staff officer and myself, the deputy commandant of the SF Academy, Lt Col David Devashyaman, who was also my CM, would be part of the group. The Battalions were located all along the border with Tibet, starting from Leh in the North, to Doom Dooma in the North-east. It was a wonderful opportunity to see the border areas and how the SFF Battalions were operating. In some places, there were a few issues between the local Army unit and the SFF unit, but our visit helped smooth them over. On one occasion, while visiting a Battalion in the Central Sector (Himachal Pradesh), we had made an unscheduled landing at an Army helipad as we were running low on fuel. The JCO there refused to do the refuelling saying that we were not 'Army'. That it was an IAF chopper with all the markings or that we were Army officers ourselves, did not have any effect on him. I had to sit down with the phone and keep calling up the chain, until the Brigade Commander of that sector finally gave the permission. It not only showed the lack of coordination between various arms of the government but also the lack of initiative at the level of the junior leadership. These were all points to note and take up formally on return

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